



Potala Palace

The world's highest palace, home to Tibet's Dalai Lamas for over 300 years, and a symbol of Tibetan unity



△ FORMIDABLE PALACE

The Potala Palace combines traditional Tibetan architecture with Indian and Chinese aesthetics. Covering 3,875,000 square ft (360,000 square m), it rises 660 ft (200 m) against a hillside.

A complex of buildings made up of the White and Red palaces and surrounding structures, the Potala Palace is situated 12,100 ft (3,700 m) above sea level on Red Mountain in Lhasa. The White Palace was built by the 5th Dalai Lama in 1645–1648 and served as his living quarters, home to over 100 monks, and the ceremonial, political, and administrative center of Tibet. The Red Palace, added in 1690–1693, was reserved for religious observances, meditation, and prayers. It also contained the gold-plated tomb of the 5th Dalai Lama. The uppermost terraces housed the palace's golden-roofed temples.

The palace grew to include more than 1,000 rooms arranged over 13 stories; 10,000 shrines; and 200,000 statues. Two other notable sites lie close to the palace: Norbulingka, the Dalai Lama's former summer palace, built in the 18th century; and the 7th-century Jokhang Temple Monastery.

▽ HOLY TOMBS

Gilded stupas containing Buddhist relics line the route to the Potala Palace, whose golden roofs are just visible above its monumental facade.



The palace has been **home** to **10 Dalai Lamas** over **371 years**